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Golden Dome may not be
the golden ticket Silicon
Valley is hoping for



Golden Dome, the Trump administration's gambit to build a next-generation missile defense system, has startups and longstanding defense contractors preparing to duke it out for a piece of a \$151 billion multi-year contract.

The process to qualify for the \$151 billion contract vehicle, essentially an umbrella program, is stacked against most startups — not because of their tech. Instead, smaller companies may be thwarted by a multi-layered, expensive bureaucratic process used to ensure a company can meet security and other compliance requirements.

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Ultimately, Golden Dome may not be the zero-sum battle of emerging tech versus incumbents. The startups that do breakthrough will be those that are able to convince the biggest defense contractors to take them on as subcontractors.

The Pentagon's Missile Defense Agency released last week [a draft solicitation](#) for a \$151 billion, multi-award contract, the prelude to the government's forthcoming defense tech buying spree.

The 10-year contract, called SHIELD, or Scalable Homeland Innovative Enterprise Layered Defense, acts as an umbrella that will be used to buy technology for the Golden Dome system. That program, which the White House likened to Israel's Iron Dome, will encompass systems that span

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space, land, and sea to protect the continental United States against a variety of missile threats.

In order to build out this system, the government will be looking to purchase a range of cutting-edge technology, like space-based interceptors, ground-based radars, and terrestrial and sea-based systems capable of taking out an enemy missile in flight. The first hurdle for companies hoping to win one of the contracts is to qualify for the umbrella program, or vehicle.

Getting onto the \$151 billion vehicle doesn't guarantee federal dollars; instead, companies will compete for contracting work on individual task orders. The final request for proposals will be released sometime in the fourth quarter of this year, though [that hasn't stopped companies from already starting their lobbying efforts.](#)

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Bryce Dabbs, CEO of consulting firm Approach Venture, told TechCrunch that he estimates between 5% and 10% of the pot could realistically

go to non-traditional vendors — not by startups competing as a prime contractor, but rather through “teaming and subcontracting arrangements,” he said, noting that not all startups are equal. For instance, SpaceX and Anduril, while backed by venture capital, are already at the scale of small primes, and the opportunity for smaller startups will likely look considerably different.

A startup with a compelling technology would need to collaborate with a defense prime, like Northrop Grumman or Lockheed, to provide a capability that the prime doesn’t currently offer in-house.

That’s because many early-stage companies lack facility clearances, personnel, IT security, or other requirements to perform highly classified government work — and the pre-solicitation warned that these barriers to entry will be in place for would-be suppliers.

Venture-backed companies like Anduril and SpaceX will be able to meet these security and compliance requirements, but everyone else will likely need to sub under a prime in order to compete.

Dabbs said his firm is seeing more early-stage founders reference Golden Dome in their decks, and that the program is frequently referenced when VCs do diligence on startups. Approach supports. But the investors “may not fully understand how government procurement or larger contracts work,” he said.

Meanwhile, more mature and cash-rich startups like SpaceX and Anduril are better poised to compete with the legacy defense contractors, such as RTX (formerly Raytheon), Lockheed Martin, Boeing, and L3Harris.

[Reuters reported](#) earlier this year that a team composed of SpaceX, Palantir, and Anduril has already started meeting with federal officials. Lockheed, meanwhile, launched a “Golden Dome for America” page on its website highlighting how it might contribute to the effort.

FAR, not fair

William Greenwalt, senior fellow at American Enterprise Institute and former deputy undersecretary of defense industrial policy at the DOD, was less optimistic. “I am not overwhelmed by the prospects for non-trationals to gain anything at all from this,” he said.

That’s because of the structure of the contract, which is being run under the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) and the Competition in Contracting Act (CICA).

While FAR requires “full and open competition,” the pathway’s high compliance standards implicitly keep newcomers out. Instead, Greenwalt said the program should be done as an Other Transaction Authority (OTA), which gives the DOD more flexibility to work with non-traditional vendors and fund prototypes with follow-on production opportunities.

“A CICA IDIQ contract is about the dumbest way to do this if you want innovation, as it will preclude non-traditionals from bidding. This should be done as an OTA — plain and simple,” he said.

Trump appointed General Michael Guetlein, second in command of the U.S. Space Force, to spearhead the initiative. He will be in charge of finalizing the program’s final architecture, which the White House wants to be in place in just three short years. That timeline favors technologies that are ready to

be deployed now, not still being worked out in R&D labs.

“Golden Dome is a bold and aggressive approach to hurry up and protect the homeland from our adversaries,” he said in May.

Topics: [defense tech](#) [Startups](#)



Aria Alamalhodaei

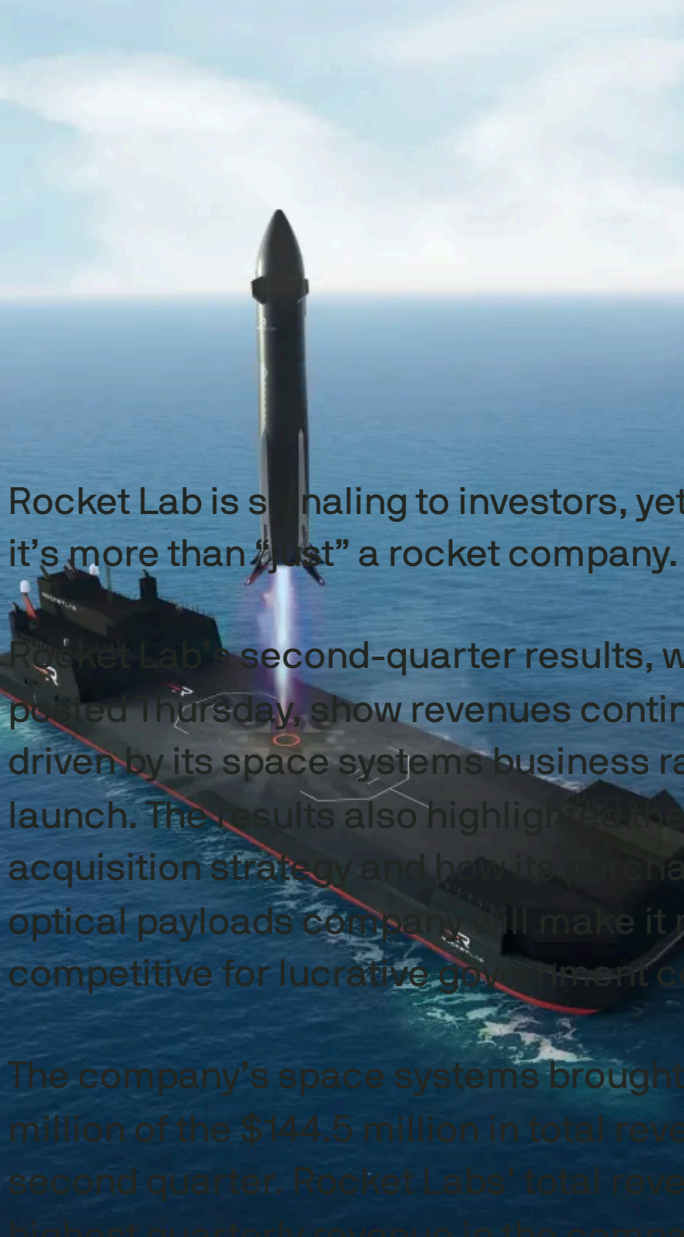
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Rocket Lab eyes big
defense opportunities
with new acquisition



Rocket Lab is signaling to investors, yet again, that it's more than "just" a rocket company.

Rocket Lab's second-quarter results, which were posted Thursday, show revenues continue to be driven by its space systems business rather than launch. The results also highlighted the company's acquisition strategy and how its purchase of a new optical payloads company will make it more competitive for lucrative government contracts.

The company's space systems brought in \$97.9 million of the \$144.5 million in total revenues for the second quarter. Rocket Labs' total revenue, its highest quarterly revenue in the company's history, jumped 36% from a year ago. The company's net loss widened to \$66.4 million.

Rocket Lab founder and CEO Peter Beck highlighted the "busy quarter of M&A activity" as the company gets close to closing its deal to buy [Geost](#), a company that builds optical payloads. Through that acquisition, which will close at \$275 million in cash and equity, Rocket Lab is opening a new business unit called Optical Systems to scale electro-optical and infrared sensor manufacturing.

Those sensors are used in missile warning, tracking, and space domain awareness. The acquisition is also one part of a larger play from Rocket Lab — spelled out quite explicitly in the company's earnings presentation — to bid for

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multibillion-dollar [DOD initiatives like Golden Dome](#).

Rocket Lab has already won some major defense contracts, including a \$515 million, 18-satellite build contract to support the Space Development Agency's constellation of missile-tracking satellites. The company has moved into production on those satellites, following confirmation that they meet the DOD's mission requirements, Rocket Lab said.

Down on Earth, Rocket Lab says it's progressing well toward the first launch of its larger Neutron rocket. The rocket's launch complex in Virginia is expected to be complete in the third quarter of this year, with [hardware en route](#) and the new rocket engine, called Archimedes, undergoing multiple tests per day.

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The company is staying vague about the exact launch date, saying only in the presentation that it

is pushing an “all-out effort to get Neutron to the launch pad before the end of 2025.”

Rocket Lab ended the quarter with \$564 million in cash and cash equivalents and estimates revenues will hit between \$145 to \$155 million next quarter.

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Aria Alamalhodaei covers the space and defense industries at TechCrunch. Previously, she covered the...

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Hubble Network plans massive satellite upgrade to create global Bluetooth layer



Aria Alamalhodaei — 4:00 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

[Hubble Network's](#) satellite-powered Bluetooth network is getting a big upgrade.

The Seattle-based startup, which aims to bring to enterprises what Apple's Find My has brought to consumers, has built a powerful new phased-array receiver that will enable what Hubble CEO Alex Haro calls a "true Bluetooth layer around the Earth."

This advanced payload will fly on two massive new satellites from four-year-old [Muon Space](#), called MuSat XL, which are slated to launch in 2027. The first two MuSat XL spacecraft will deliver a 12-hour global revisit time and detect Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE) signals at 30 times lower power than current capabilities, Hubble says. If those numbers pan out, it could materially extend battery life for tracking tags and sensors here on Earth.

Those two satellites will form the backbone of Hubble's BLE Finding Network for enterprises in sectors ranging from logistics, infrastructure, and defense.

Hubble [made history in 2024](#) when it became the first company to establish a Bluetooth connection directly to a satellite. The startup's proposition is compelling: Instead of needing to buy specialized hardware, customers will only need to integrate their devices' chipsets with a piece of firmware to enable connection to the Hubble network.

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The benefits of the space-based network are massive, Hubble argues: It can provide visibility across the globe, including in remote areas, and offers a developer-friendly way to let companies track assets without building any additional infrastructure.

The company currently has seven spacecraft on orbit with a target of having 60 satellites in operation by 2028. The long-term goal is to upgrade the entire constellation to the larger platform buses because of their power and performance upgrades, Haro said.



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It's an aggressive schedule, but Haro added that one reason Hubble chose to partner with Muon is the latter's ability to rapidly scale manufacturing to hit this goal, despite being a young company. (A recent [\\$146 million funding round](#) should help.) Gregory Smirin, president of Muon Space, told TechCrunch that the company's San Jose production facility is being built out to support

production of over 500 spacecraft per year by 2027.

Hubble is the first customer for the 500 kilogram-class MuSat XL satellite platform, which Muon says can provide multi-kilowatt power to payloads, optical crosslinks, high-volume downlink, and “near real-time” communications for time-sensitive missions. The partnership also signals a bigger push by the company to compete for more lucrative contracts with the Department of Defense.

The XL platform “is a perfect size and capability for SDA Tranche missions,” Smirin said, referring to the Space Development Agency’s initiative to build out a missile defense constellation in low Earth orbit. “XL reflects both the evolution of our technical stack and our growing role in delivering the kind of multi-mission spacecraft that programs like SDA increasingly rely on.”

Muon’s business model can be thought of as [space-as-a-service](#): The company designs, builds, and operates satellites using a vertically integrated stack of hardware and software. The stack, called Halo, is meant to open up space access for companies with promising payloads but no interest in building the underlying satellite architecture. In practice, that means Hubble can focus on developing the BLE network while Muon handles the satellite platforms and mission operations.

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